

Meaning Does Not Travel

A Non-Transfer Model of Publicization and Semantic Sharing

Shohei KIMURA

18 September 2026

Abstract

When does meaning become public? The question conflates the production of an external medium, its connection to public circulation, and its interpretation by another subject. This article develops a conceptual model that distinguishes a source-local meaning-state A, an external stimulus S, and a receiver-local meaning-state A'. Meaning-state tokens are not identical to the media generated from them or to their subsequent reconstructions. This non-identity does not preclude shared propositional content, accurate understanding, or empirical knowledge of another subject. Publicization is defined separately from semantic sharing: relative to an independently specified public circuit, a stimulus becomes publicly connected when multiple others can access a common referent and receiver-side responses can enter the same or another public circuit. Actual reception, direct reply, successful reconstruction, and permanent recording are not necessary for this connection. Consequently, publicization can occur without sharing, while sharing can occur outside public circulation. The model also separates an operational public-connection onset from the literal migration of a meaning-state, and treats contestability, verification, correction, and traceability as additional evaluative dimensions rather than constitutive conditions of connection. The argument is situated in relation to conduit-metaphor criticism, inferential pragmatics, public-sphere theory, semantic externalism, and extended or participatory cognition. Its contribution is a conditional architecture for distinguishing communication events, not an exhaustive theory of meaning or a universal definition of the public.

Keywords: publicization; semantic sharing; meaning-state; public circuits; non-transfer; reconstruction; Ethicalism

1. The problem: an event without a specified criterion

The question 'At what moment does meaning move into the public?' appears to ask for a date, a threshold, or a transition. Yet it leaves at least three matters unsettled: what entity is supposed to move, what counts as the public, and what event would count as arrival. A manuscript may become accessible without being read. A reader may understand it without answering its author. An interpretation may circulate through a different institution from the one that first made the manuscript available. Treating all these events as a single movement obscures distinctions that the question itself requires.

This article reconstructs and extends definitions 94.1–94.7 of the Ethicalism Definition System (Kimura, 2026a, 2026b, 2026c). It advances a limited but explicit thesis: in an account that individuates meaning-states by their realization in distinct thinking systems, publicization concerns the connection of external stimuli to public circuits, whereas semantic sharing concerns receiver-local reconstruction. Neither event is the numerical migration of the source's meaning-state. The thesis does not deny that the same proposition can be understood by several people, that information can be transmitted, or that public practices can determine semantic content.

The first difficulty is one of question specification. Without an account of the relevant public and its connection conditions, no unique public-transition criterion follows. This does not make every ordinary question using an undefined word meaningless. Publicness can be contextually understood, and investigating its definition can itself be philosophically productive. The narrower point is that a demand for a determinate transition point cannot be answered independently of the criterion by which the transition is identified. An absent criterion should not be mistaken for an elusive event waiting to be measured.

The second difficulty survives a complete specification of the public. A source-local state, an emitted signal, and a receiver-local state must still be distinguished. Their causal connection does not establish their numerical identity. Public circulation therefore requires an account of what circulates, not merely an account of where it circulates. The present model locates circulation at the level of external stimuli while retaining locally realized interpretation at the level of thinking systems.

The method is conceptual analysis supported by explicit definitions, conditional propositions, and counterexamples. It is not a report of an experiment or a systematic review establishing historical priority. The model is assessed by whether it distinguishes cases

without illicitly deriving understanding from availability, legitimacy from circulation, or token identity from accurate reconstruction. Sections 2 and 3 establish its intellectual position and core vocabulary. Sections 4–7 develop connection, sharing, temporal onset, and observation. Sections 8 and 9 examine objections and diagnostic uses. Appendix A documents the relationship to the source definitions, including qualifications introduced during their development.

2. Intellectual position: reconstruction is not a new discovery

Reddy's critique of the conduit metaphor is a direct antecedent. His analysis challenges expressions that represent mental contents as objects placed inside words and extracted by recipients. His alternative emphasizes constructive activity on the receiving side rather than automatic delivery of a ready-made interior object (Reddy, 1993). Accordingly, the present article does not claim to discover that communication involves reconstruction. It asks what follows when this established distinction is combined with a separate account of public connection. The intended contribution is the coordinated separation of predicates, not the unprecedentedness of every component.

Shannon's mathematical theory explicitly brackets semantic considerations when specifying the engineering problem of communication (Shannon, 1948). It is therefore not evidence that semantic content is impossible, nor is it a naive theory of meanings travelling between minds. The distinction between a transmitted signal and an interpreted state is compatible with treating signal reproduction as an engineering objective. Nothing here prevents exact transmission of a bit sequence. The question is what such exactness establishes about the identity, interpretation, or public status of the states associated with that sequence.

Inferential pragmatics also provides a relevant precedent. Sperber and Wilson distinguish coding from communication through evidence that supports inference about a communicator's intentions; linguistic decoding can contribute to, without exhausting, interpretation (Sperber & Wilson, 1987). The model developed below similarly does not make recipient understanding a mechanical consequence of signal reception. It is broader in modality but narrower in explanatory ambition: it does not supply a general algorithm for inference, a theory of relevance, or a necessary role for intention in every publicly circulating stimulus.

Clark and Brennan's account of grounding concerns the coordination through which participants establish understanding sufficient for their current purposes (Clark & Brennan, 1991). This helps distinguish successful interaction from mere exposure. However, the

threshold proposed here is deliberately weaker than conversational grounding. A stimulus may enter public circulation before anyone supplies evidence of understanding, and a reader need not establish mutual understanding with its author. Grounding and public connection answer different questions rather than compete for one definition of communication.

Public-sphere theories introduce another distinction. Habermas connects the public sphere to access, discussion, and the formation of public opinion, with freedoms of expression and assembly integral to his account (Habermas, 1974). Fraser's analysis of multiple and counterpublic arenas challenges treating public discourse as a single homogeneous domain (Fraser, 1990). These accounts address issues that a bare connectivity model cannot settle. The present article borrows neither a complete public/private boundary nor a theory of legitimacy from them. It represents public domains as separately specified parameters so that different circuits and different evaluative standards can be distinguished.

Warner presents an especially important limit. His account connects publics to reflexive circulation and makes attention or uptake constitutive of a discursive public (Warner, 2002, pp. 60–62). An entirely unattended broadcast therefore cannot simply be invoked against his theory as though both accounts explained the same object. This article concerns a stimulus's connection to an already specified public circuit, including an institutional communication infrastructure. The formation of an audience-defined discursive public is a further event. Keeping those targets separate is essential to the zero-reception case developed below.

3. Meaning-states, external stimuli, and local reconstruction

3.1. The unit of analysis

A thinking system *X* is a functionally individuated system capable of realizing the internal interpretive states relevant to the inquiry. The category is not restricted by definition to human brains or biological substrates. Its possible members include nonhuman and artificial systems, provided the relevant interpretive capacities are independently established. This extension does not assert that every computational process is a subject, that current artificial systems are conscious, or that substrate alone establishes semantic capacity.

A meaning-state *A* is a particular realization, within *X*, of an interpretation involving some combination of conceptual organization, memory, inference, evaluation, affect, and practical orientation. Not every state must contain every component. The term designates an occurrent or dispositional configuration for a specified episode, not an abstract proposition detached from its realization. It also does not identify meaning with a fixed, directly

measurable neural pattern. The model leaves the level at which X and A are individuated explicit and open to the relevant account of cognition.

An external stimulus S is a publicly or privately accessible arrangement or change that can become input to another thinking system. 'Stimulus' includes written language, speech, images, mathematical notation, gestures, code, recorded measurements, and combinations of these. A stimulus need not be a temporal string: a diagram or spatial arrangement can occupy the same role. The medium is considered here in its instantiated, externally accessible form. Its physical substrate, formal organization, and interpretation are distinguishable even when ordinary speech calls all three the message.

An interpretation generated in another system Y is initially denoted B. It is written A' only when an independently specified relation makes it an appropriate reconstruction of A for the purpose under consideration. This convention prevents the mere occurrence of any reaction from counting as semantic sharing. Startlement at a sound, for example, need not be an interpretation of the claim articulated by that sound.

3.2. Two productive relations, not a travelling interior object

Let G represent the generation of S from a source episode involving A, and let U represent the production of B through uptake of S by Y. Both relations may depend on context, prior histories, embodiment, and other inputs. They are not assumed to be deterministic, one-to-one, or invertible. The elementary architecture is:

$$G(X, A, c_X; S) \text{ and } U(Y, S, c_Y; B). \quad (1)$$

Here c_X and c_Y collect relevant contextual conditions. The semicolon separates inputs from the generated term without identifying them. In an ordinary two-system communication episode, A is not S, and the state B realized in Y is not the state-token A realized in X. A relation of production is not a relation of numerical identity. Copying an external representation, preserving a formal structure, or reconstructing an interpretation need not transport the original state-token.

The qualification 'ordinary two-system episode' matters. The claim is conditional on independently individuated source and receiver systems. It does not prove that every conceivable process of physical relocation, brain replacement, or system merger is impossible. Such cases require an additional account of persistence and system identity. The model rejects a token-migration description of the specified communicative architecture; it does not derive a universal physical prohibition from terminology alone.

Nor does non-transfer require A to remain unchanged or to exist forever. Expression may transform the source's interpretation, and A may cease before S is read. An author's later death does not erase the possibility of a subsequent public connection of the author's text. What persists, when anything does, may be the stimulus and its causal provenance, not the originating experience. Non-transfer is therefore a claim about the relation among entities, not a conservation law for mental states.

3.3. Numerical non-identity does not entail semantic error

Two distinct state-tokens may instantiate the same proposition, support the same inference, or be equivalent for a task. Conversely, similar behavior can mask interpretive differences. The distinction A versus A' neither establishes nor excludes semantic equivalence. Treating every difference of realization as a misunderstanding would confuse numerical identity with adequacy of interpretation.

Let $N_k(A, B)$ designate whatever relation of interpretive correspondence is appropriate under an independently specified criterion k. The criterion might concern reference, inferential consequences, practical understanding, or another established standard. This article does not select a metric, a universal tolerance, or a privileged measurement procedure. N_k need not be symmetric or transitive, and the word 'neighborhood' need not imply a geometrical distance. It marks correspondence without requiring identical realization.

Leaving k open is not a solution to the measurement of understanding. It identifies the boundary of the present question. A particular claim that sharing has occurred requires a defensible criterion and evidence; the public-connection predicate developed below does not. The separation can therefore be argued without first solving a general problem of comparing internal states. It is a framework for locating that problem, not a device for declaring every interpretation equally adequate.

4. Public connection as accessibility and potential circulation

4.1. Public designation is a parameter, not an output

Let P^* be a family of circuits independently designated as public for the inquiry. A member P might be specified institutionally, legally, sociologically, or by a separate philosophical account. The model does not decide whether a family conversation, invitation-only group, professional association, or local discussion belongs to P^* . Those boundary judgments must be supplied by the account making the designation. No unrestricted-audience or anonymous-membership requirement is silently added.

A public circuit is represented functionally rather than as a physical container. Its specification concerns arrangements through which references become accessible and responses can re-enter circulation. The family P^* need not consist of mutually isolated domains. A broadcast, a printed response, and an online discussion can be connected while remaining distinguishable routes. This representation accommodates plurality without claiming that all circuits share a single verification practice or institutional authority.

The following conditions consequently define connection relative to an admitted P . They are not a sufficient, context-free definition of what should count as public. This restriction prevents a circular derivation in which 'public' is explained only by 'public circulation': public designation is an input, and a stimulus's connection to that designated structure is the output.

4.2. Accessibility and response possibility

The accessibility condition $E(S, P, t)$ holds when, at time t , multiple others can refer to S through P . 'Can' concerns genuinely available access under the specified circumstances, not actual access by a measured audience. Multiple people need not hold the same physical carrier. Attributable copies can support reference to the same external item or stimulus episode. Whether two files or performances are instances of one identified item is an external provenance question, not an assumption that their audiences share identical meanings.

Accessibility alone is insufficient in the proposed model. A wholly sealed one-directional delivery system provides no route by which receiver-side reactions can become available to others. The circulation condition $R(S, P, P^*, t)$ therefore requires an available pathway through which a possible receiver of S can re-externalize a response concerning it into some Q belonging to P^* . Q may be P , but need not be. The response does not have to reach the original producer, and the originating institution need not acknowledge it.

The modality here is practical possibility under the prevailing configuration. It is not enough that a route would exist after an imagined revolution in infrastructure, permissions, or physical capacity. At least a genuine receiver-side pathway must be available for the episode. Conversely, people need not exercise that pathway. An available route for public comment remains a route during silence. When the existence of a route is uncertain, the proper classification is uncertain rather than automatically connected.

Neither universal access nor equal response power follows from this minimum. A route can be limited, costly, or restricted in its acceptable forms. The present predicate records whether the specified circulation structure exists, while a fuller account records who is

excluded and what responses are inhibited. A response can express assent, a question, a report, or another publicly referable reaction; it need not be an objection. This is why feedback possibility and freedom to challenge are not interchangeable conditions.

For an already designated P , public connection is defined by:

$$C(S, P, P^*, t) \text{ iff } E(S, P, t) \text{ and } R(S, P, P^*, t). \quad (2)$$

The definition separates the item, route, network, and time. It also allows access and response possibilities to change. A stimulus can lose current accessibility even though its earlier connection remains a fact. A routing arrangement can close while a retained copy later enters another circuit. No permanent public status is inferred from a single historical connection.

4.3. No direct reply, actual uptake, or archival persistence requirement

Consider a broadcaster whose audience cannot contact the original speaker but can discuss the program in another admitted public forum. The lack of a direct return channel does not make the overall arrangement one-directional. What matters is potential circulation through the relevant network, not conversational symmetry between two named endpoints. This applies equally to written, visual, numerical, or gestural stimuli when the required access and response routes exist.

Now suppose that a technically accessible broadcast, within an independently designated public circuit, is actually received by nobody. Its access arrangements and feasible response routes can nevertheless remain intact. C can therefore be true even though no receiver-local A' is generated. This is a thought experiment stipulating genuine zero reception. A measured rating of zero would not, without additional evidence, establish that premise. The conceptual case concerns the absence of reception itself, not the interpretation of audience statistics.

Permanent storage is likewise unnecessary. An unrecorded live address can meet both conditions during its occurrence. Subsequent responses can concern a transient event, and the circuit need not preserve the original signal indefinitely. Traceability is valuable for some inquiries, but requiring a durable archive would make the classification depend on a different property from accessibility and circulation at the relevant time.

4.4. Connection and evaluative quality

Verification, contestability, correction, and traceability are distinct predicates that can be attached to a connected episode. They describe what can be checked, challenged, revised, or

reconstructed from records. They need not be collapsed into one aggregate score, and the present account does not rank institutions by them. A circuit can permit responses while preventing certain challenges; it can preserve messages while providing no reliable correction procedure.

Keeping these predicates separate allows the account to describe restrictive or unreliable circulation without treating it as a logical absence of every public structure. It does not endorse that structure or pronounce it legitimate. Equally, a richer theory may reserve 'public sphere' for arrangements with stronger conditions. In that vocabulary, the present predicate should be read as minimal public-circuit connection, not as an attempt to defeat the richer theory by renaming its subject.

5. Publicization and semantic sharing are non-equivalent

5.1. Separate predicates

Publicization, in this article, is the occurrence or establishment of C for S in an admitted public circuit. It is a relation between a stimulus and a circulation arrangement. Semantic sharing is an actual receiver-side achievement: S contributes to a state B in a system Y distinct from X , and B stands in N_k to the relevant source-state A . Where the relation holds, B is denoted A' . The source need not observe the reconstruction or receive evidence of it.

For an episode up to time t , let $U_{\leq t}$ denote actual uptake completed by that time. The sharing predicate can be expressed as:

$$H_k(A, S, t) \Leftrightarrow \exists Y \exists B [Y \neq X \wedge U_{\leq t}(Y, S, c_Y; B) \wedge N_k(A, B)]. \quad (3)$$

Equation (3) is an episode-level predicate, not a claim that one recipient's understanding establishes consensus. It does not require mutual awareness, a stable community interpretation, or a successful collective decision. Such stronger notions may be defined by adding conditions. It also requires a relevant uptake relation: an unrelated but similar thought elsewhere is not sharing through this S .

5.2. The separation proposition

Proposition 1. Over the class of admissible models, publicization does not entail semantic sharing, and semantic sharing does not entail publicization.

For the first direction, take the zero-reception broadcast stipulated in Section 4.3. Multiple others have available access and a feasible response pathway, so C holds. No other system

actually receives S, so equation (3) has no witness. H_k fails independently of how interpretive correspondence is measured. Publicization without sharing is therefore a consistent case.

For the second direction, take a parameterization that recognizes a private exchange outside its designated public family. A source sends S to another system, and an adequate interpretation is actually reconstructed there. H_k holds, but no connection satisfying C exists in an admitted public circuit. This establishes non-entailment without deciding which real-world relationships must count as private. A theory that designates every exchange public removes this particular counterexample from its domain, but does not make shared meaning itself supply that designation.

The four possibilities are summarized in Table 1. Their availability is logical rather than statistical. The article makes no claim that accessibility and understanding are probabilistically independent in actual populations. Public connection can make uptake possible or more likely without guaranteeing that it occurs. Likewise, successful understanding can motivate later public dissemination without already constituting it.

Table 1. Publicization and semantic sharing: distinct case classifications.

Publicization	Sharing	Illustrative case
Present	Present	A connected item is actually taken up and gives rise to A' under the specified criterion.
Present	Absent	An accessible item with a feasible response route receives no actual uptake.
Absent	Present	Adequate reconstruction occurs in an exchange designated private by the adopted account.
Absent	Absent	An uncirculated draft has neither a qualifying public connection nor receiver reconstruction.

Note. These are logical possibilities across admissible specifications, not a claim of statistical independence.

The proposition blocks two familiar inferences: availability does not establish understanding, and understanding does not establish public status. It also avoids defining publicization by popularity. Additional readers increase realized reception, but their number is not substituted for the two structural conditions. A text with little attention and a widely discussed text can both be connected while exhibiting very different reception histories.

5.3. Sharing is not the source's monopoly over interpretation

N_k does not give the producer unilateral authority over all legitimate uses of S . A receiver can generate a valuable criticism, a new association, or a reinterpretation that departs from the source's intentions. Such a state may fail a particular source-fidelity criterion while succeeding under another criterion appropriate to criticism or invention. The model distinguishes these projects rather than classifying every departure as error.

Sharing is also distinct from truth. Two parties may reconstruct the same false proposition with great accuracy. Conversely, a receiver may correct a source's false belief and thereby differ from it while improving the account of the world. The dimensions of source correspondence, evidential warrant, practical adequacy, and public circulation should therefore be evaluated separately. Non-transfer provides no shortcut from interpretive closeness to epistemic merit.

6. Public-connection onset without a meaning-migration instant

The operational question of time survives the rejection of literal meaning migration. For a specified S , P , and P^* , define the set T of times at which C holds. If T has a least element within the relevant episode, that time is the public-connection onset:

$$t_c = \min \{ t : C(S, P, P^*, t) \}, \text{ when this minimum exists.} \quad (4)$$

A completed publication operation, a broadcast beginning, or the opening of an access route can supply such a boundary when it establishes the specified conditions. The administrative label on an operation does not suffice by itself. A file marked 'published' but inaccessible to the relevant audience may not yet satisfy E ; a functioning access route without the required circulation possibility may not satisfy R .

Proposition 2. Within the token-individuating model, a public-connection onset can exist without any meaning-migration event.

At t_c , the conjunction of access and circulation conditions becomes true of S . Neither conjunct states that A leaves X or becomes identical to a state in another system. The event can occur with no recipient present. Consequently, its existence does not imply either literal token migration or actual reconstruction. Conversely, denying literal migration does not deny a change in the external connection predicate. These are differently typed events.

Not every case supplies a precise point. Gradual access expansion, indeterminate institutional boundaries, uncertain records, or an open temporal threshold may justify only an

interval, an infimum, or a qualified determination. An infimum that is not attained is not silently treated as a minimum. The model permits precise onset where the specification supports it; it does not claim that all publicization has a uniquely recoverable instant.

Different circuits can also have different onsets for an attributable stimulus. Entry into one does not automatically settle entry into another. A later reproduction may count as a new stimulus instance with its own provenance and connection history. The relevant questions are which item, which circuit, which structural conditions, and which time. The singular phrase 'the moment meaning became public' should not conceal this indexing.

7. Observation and inference do not acquire the source-state

An observer may obtain speech, behavior, recordings, computational logs, or measurements bearing on a source-state A . Let O be an observation record and let $\hat{A}$ be a state or representation formed by another system on the basis of O . The model distinguishes the source-state, the record, and the resulting estimate. These may stand in strong evidential relations without becoming one numerically identical event.

Proposition 3. Increased accuracy in inferring A does not, by itself, constitute acquisition of the original A -token.

The claim follows from the distinction between an estimate's adequacy and the identity of its realization. An estimate can be accurate, even equivalent in every selected descriptive respect, while occurring in another system. The proposition does not depend on an inevitable residual inaccuracy. It would still apply to a hypothetical perfect reconstruction under the chosen criteria. Accuracy removes error under those criteria, not the distinction between the original event and the estimating event.

Importantly, this is not a doctrine of radical inaccessibility. Physical aspects of internal processing can in principle be observed or measured; evidence can support genuine knowledge of another subject. The claim does not require every observation to concern only outward behavior. It concerns the inference from observing or representing a state to possessing that very source-state as one's own token. That inference needs an account of identity and realization which improved measurement alone does not provide.

As an empirical illustration rather than a proof, Tang and colleagues developed a decoder that reconstructed semantic information from non-invasive brain recordings under the conditions of their study (Tang et al., 2023). Such work concerns evidentially supported

reconstruction, not the numerical relocation of a participant's original state. Its existence also cautions against turning the present distinction into an unsupported prediction that internal states can never be studied. The conceptual claim remains compatible with substantial, context-dependent advances in observation.

8. Objections and limits of the model

8.1. Is non-transfer merely stipulated?

The strongest objection is that a state-token has been defined locally and is then unsurprisingly declared non-transferable. In that respect, the bare non-identity result is conditional and should not be advertised as an empirical discovery. The model's further work lies in showing that several familiar inferences do not follow even when successful communication is granted. Exact signal transmission does not entail shared interpretation; shared interpretation does not entail public connection; connection does not entail active uptake; an onset need not be a migration.

These distinctions earn their place by discriminating cases and identifying the evidence needed for each claim. A rival account can reject the local-state framework while still needing separate predicates for publication and reception. Thus the publicization–sharing separation is less metaphysically demanding than the strongest possible reading of 'meaning does not travel'. The title names the account's token-level thesis, not a prohibition on ordinary expressions such as 'communicating an idea'.

8.2. Does internal realization imply a private language?

Wittgenstein's discussion of private sensation language, particularly §§243–258, challenges an account on which inward association alone supplies a usable criterion of correctness (Wittgenstein, 2009). Calling A internal must not therefore be taken as demonstrating that a person's private occurrence independently fixes every linguistic norm. A theory of internal episodes cannot simply replace an account of publicly intelligible rule-following.

The present model locates a realization without making correctness exclusively private. Its own terms, including its descriptions of A and its criteria k, remain subject to shared practices of explanation and assessment. It neither proves nor requires that a wholly private naming ceremony establishes meaning. Where the stronger claim is intended, the private-language objection remains unresolved by token non-identity alone. The restricted model avoids relying on that stronger claim rather than pretending to refute the objection.

8.3. What about semantic externalism?

Putnam's argument concerning the individuation of meaning challenges the idea that psychological states alone determine linguistic meaning or extension (Putnam, 1975). This directly matters if 'meaning is internal' is presented as an exhaustive theory of semantic content. The location of a token realization cannot establish that its content is fixed independently of environmental and social relations.

Accordingly, A is an internally realized interpretive state, while its content can depend on relations extending beyond X. This distinguishes the realization of an episode from the conditions that individuate what it is about. It does not derive internalism about reference from a model of production and uptake. A reader who uses 'meaning' exclusively for an externally individuated abstract content should read A as 'meaning-state', not as a reduction of that content to an intrinsic configuration. Publicly shared content is compatible with distinct local realizations.

8.4. Extended and participatory cognition

Clark and Chalmers argue that cognitive processes may include appropriately coupled external resources rather than stop at the organism's boundary (Clark & Chalmers, 1998). A response cannot simply label every artifact external because it lies outside a skull. The system boundary adopted for a particular analysis must be defended. If a notebook or computational resource is constitutive of X, its state may belong within X under that individuation rather than automatically count as an external communication medium.

This qualification does not make boundary choice cost-free. When X and Y overlap or jointly depend on one constitutive resource, the simple distinct-system model may require revision. The current argument applies where the relevant source, medium, and receiver roles can be distinguished; it does not prove that all cognition admits that decomposition. An artifact may be internal to one coupled process and external relative to another, so the reference system must be specified.

De Jaegher and Di Paolo's account of participatory sense-making treats interaction as potentially constitutive of meaning generation, not merely as the transport of independently completed meanings (De Jaegher & Di Paolo, 2007). The present G–U scheme can represent iterative change, in which producing and receiving successive stimuli transform both participants. It therefore need not assume a permanently preformed A. However, if the primary explanatory unit is an irreducibly interactional process, local-state reconstruction may

be a partial description rather than a complete account. This is a scope limitation, not an established refutation of the enactive alternative.

8.5. Can an unattended item have a public?

Warner's attention-based account makes the imagined unattended broadcast a boundary case, not a decisive counterexample to every theory of publics (Warner, 2002). The current model distinguishes the existence of an admitted circuit, the connection of an item to it, and the formation of an actual discursive audience. It asserts the second without requiring the third; it does not infer a newly assembled public from nobody's attention.

An account that defines P itself through this very item's actual reception will not admit the same zero-reception classification. That is a disagreement about the input designation and explanatory target. Stating it openly is preferable to using one sense of 'public' in the premises and another in the result. The article's claim is most straightforward for institutional or otherwise independently specified circuits, and remains conditional for attention-constituted publics.

8.6. Is publicness smuggled into the response condition?

R refers to a public circuit Q, but Q is drawn from the independently supplied family P^* . The model therefore does not purport to derive publicness from itself. It answers a downstream question: given these designated circuits and their current affordances, is S connected in the stipulated structural sense? It cannot settle a disputed designation when the disputants have supplied incompatible public/private boundaries.

Requiring response possibility is nevertheless a substantive modeling choice. A different theory might count an absolutely one-directional system as public. The present account excludes that structure from its particular connection predicate, even if it retains public institutional status under another account. The exclusion must not be disguised as an ordinary-language necessity. Its rationale is to distinguish mere delivery from a network in which receiver-side consequences can themselves become referable.

8.7. Artificial systems, copying, and limits of attribution

Extending the domain beyond biology does not authorize attributing an integrated meaning-state to every text generator. Whether a particular system realizes the relevant state remains a separate question. The model offers conditional vocabulary for describing it, not a test for

consciousness or an automatic assignment of personhood. A system's producing a public stimulus also does not, by itself, establish every property attributed to the source role.

Likewise, exact copying of a file or a computational configuration can preserve its type or descriptive organization while generating another token. That distinction is compatible with ordinary engineering talk of 'moving data'. A stronger claim about the migration of a numerically identical cognitive subject would require criteria of continuity not supplied here. Neither everyday file-transfer terminology nor a speculative copying scenario alone settles those criteria.

9. Diagnostic uses, implications, and remaining questions

The model's practical value is diagnostic rather than predictive. Suppose an externally available document attracts no readers. The issue concerns uptake, not necessarily public connection. Suppose it is read but differently interpreted. The issue concerns reconstruction under a stated criterion, not necessarily access. Suppose it is accurately understood yet its claim is false. The issue concerns evidence or truth, not fidelity of transmission. Suppose a correction is produced but cannot reach the relevant audience. The issue concerns a further stimulus's routing and accessibility. These distinctions identify different objects of inquiry without assuming that one universal repair procedure covers them all.

They also prevent a blanket account of misinformation or generated falsehoods as the receiver's divergence from a correct source. A source can already be mistaken, a medium can be altered, an attribution can be fabricated, or a recipient can reason badly from an accurately reconstructed claim. Even a perfect A–A' correspondence would not eliminate the first possibility. The article therefore treats source formation, stimulus provenance, uptake, interpretation, and evidential checking as separable analytical locations. Which location explains a real failure requires evidence.

A further implication concerns responsibility. The numerical distinctness of receiver-side states does not absolve a producer of responsibility for misleading expression, nor does it make every misunderstanding the producer's fault. Causal contribution, available alternatives, foreseeable effects, and institutional obligations require additional analysis. The limited result is negative: token non-identity alone establishes neither moral innocence nor moral blame. Similarly, the existence of a correction route does not prove that an adequate correction was made or that affected readers encountered it.

The proposal yields testable applications only after its parameters are operationalized. An empirical study could specify admitted public circuits, document feasible access and response routes, distinguish those routes from actual reception, and then evaluate interpretation under an independently defended criterion. Such a study could discover that the proposed categories fail to capture important cases or that route availability was incorrectly inferred. None of those observations is supplied by the present conceptual analysis. Its propositions constrain interpretation of evidence; they do not substitute for collecting it.

Several matters remain deliberately outside the article's settlement: the extension of the public/private boundary, a universal measure of semantic neighborhood, sufficient conditions for artificial meaning, and a complete ontology of distributed cognition. Leaving those matters open does not make them trivial. It prevents their unresolved status from being imported as a demand that every public-connection question first solve the entire philosophy of meaning. Conversely, any stronger conclusion depending on those matters must state the additional premise it needs.

The resulting reconstruction of the opening question is precise: which external stimulus became connected to which independently specified public circuit, under which access and circulation conditions, and when? A different question asks whether a recipient actually reconstructed an interpretation, with what correspondence, and on what evidence. In the adopted model, no single meaning-state must travel between systems for either question to have an answer. Publicization identifies a relational change in external circulation; semantic sharing identifies an achievement of interpretation. Their separation preserves an operational onset without turning a medium into the meaning-state from which it was generated.

Authorial provenance and research transparency

First authored by Shohei KIMURA. The conceptual source is the author's Ethicalism Definition System, definitions 94.1–94.7 and the clarifications developed with them. The literary name Yōhaku Kimura appears on the originating definition records; the scholarly author is Shohei KIMURA.

This is a conceptual article. It reports no newly collected participant data or empirical experiment, and its examples are analytical cases unless a published study is expressly cited. ChatGPT assisted with English drafting, literature retrieval, organization, and document preparation from the author's source definitions and explicit clarifications. This assistance does not constitute independent empirical validation or a claim of exhaustive literature coverage.

Appendix A. Provenance and correspondence with definitions 94.1–94.7

The originating definitions belong to the author's Ethicalism Definition System. Definitions D-A and D-B were dated 10 February 2026; D-C through D-G were developed on 18 September 2026. They are author-originating conceptual sources, not independent empirical confirmation of the claims defended here. The English labels below are descriptive translations for this manuscript. The original definition records are preserved rather than silently rewritten.

Table 2. Source definitions and their roles in this article.

Source	Conceptual role	Treatment in the manuscript
94.1 / D-A	Question specification	Sections 1 and 6 retain the need for a specified public and an operational transition criterion.
94.2 / D-B	Meaning non-transfer	Section 3 distinguishes local realization from the medium and from receiver reconstruction.
94.3 / D-C	Meaning–medium non-identity	Section 3 generalizes stimuli beyond language and extends the possible system domain beyond biology.
94.4 / D-D	Potential public circulation	Section 4 specifies accessibility and same- or cross-circuit response possibility without actual uptake.
94.5 / D-E	Publicization–sharing separation	Section 5 distinguishes circuit connection from actual reconstruction under an independently chosen criterion.
94.6 / D-F	Inference without token acquisition	Section 7 distinguishes observation and accurate estimation from possession of the original state-token.
94.7 / D-G	Operational onset without migration	Section 6 preserves a possible public-connection onset while rejecting a literal token-migration interpretation.

Three developmental qualifications govern this article's reconstruction. First, D-A's earlier verification-and-correction threshold is not retained as the minimum condition for connection. D-D distinguishes connection from those evaluative safeguards. Second, D-B's earlier coupling of publicization with stabilized near-reconstruction is qualified by D-E: connection does not require actual A' generation. Third, D-B's language-centered formulation is generalized by D-C to external stimuli across modalities. These are substantive clarifications, not merely new labels for an unchanged formulation.

The article also separates numerical non-identity from semantic inaccuracy, does not require a source-state to persist indefinitely, and does not treat a physically internal state as necessarily unknowable. These qualifications delimit the arguments that follow from the source definitions. They avoid importing stronger conclusions about consciousness, reference, measurement, or public legitimacy than the publicization problem requires.

References

- Clark, A., & Chalmers, D. J. (1998). The extended mind. *Analysis*, 58(1), 7–19.
<https://doi.org/10.1093/analys/58.1.7>
- Clark, H. H., & Brennan, S. E. (1991). Grounding in communication. In L. B. Resnick, J. M. Levine, & S. D. Teasley (Eds.), *Perspectives on socially shared cognition* (pp. 127–149). American Psychological Association.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/10096-006>
- De Jaegher, H., & Di Paolo, E. (2007). Participatory sense-making: An enactive approach to social cognition. *Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences*, 6, 485–507.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s11097-007-9076-9>
- Fraser, N. (1990). Rethinking the public sphere: A contribution to the critique of actually existing democracy. *Social Text*, 25/26, 56–80.
<https://doi.org/10.2307/466240>
- Habermas, J. (1974). The public sphere: An encyclopedia article (1964) (S. Lennox & F. Lennox, Trans.). *New German Critique*, 3, 49–55.
<https://doi.org/10.2307/487737>
- Kimura, S. (2026a, February 10). *Definition D-A: The ill-posedness of the transition question under an unspecified public* [Japanese definition; Ethicalism Definition System, 94.1]. X.
<https://x.com/yohakukmr/status/2021434039803204057>
- Kimura, S. (2026b, February 10). *Definition D-B: Meaning non-transfer and sharing through near-reconstruction* [Japanese definition; Ethicalism Definition System, 94.2]. X.
<https://x.com/yohakukmr/status/2021434058362978701>
- Kimura, S. (2026c, September 18). *Ethicalism Definition System: Definitions 94.3–94.7 (D-C–D-G)* [Unpublished Japanese author manuscript].
- Putnam, H. (1975). The meaning of 'meaning'. In *Mind, language and reality: Philosophical papers* (Vol. 2, pp. 215–271). Cambridge University Press.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511625251.014>
- Reddy, M. J. (1993). The conduit metaphor: A case of frame conflict in our language about language. In A. Ortony (Ed.), *Metaphor and thought* (2nd ed., pp. 164–201). Cambridge University Press.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781139173865.012>
- Shannon, C. E. (1948). A mathematical theory of communication. *The Bell System Technical Journal*, 27, 379–423, 623–656.
<https://people.math.harvard.edu/~ctm/home/text/others/shannon/entropy/entropy.pdf>
- Sperber, D., & Wilson, D. (1987). Précis of Relevance: Communication and Cognition. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 10(4), 697–710.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X00055345>
- Tang, J., LeBel, A., Jain, S., & Huth, A. G. (2023). Semantic reconstruction of continuous language from non-invasive brain recordings. *Nature Neuroscience*, 26, 858–866.
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s41593-023-01304-9>
- Warner, M. (2002). Publics and counterpublics. *Public Culture*, 14(1), 49–90.
<https://doi.org/10.1215/08992363-14-1-49>
- Wittgenstein, L. (2009). *Philosophical investigations* (G. E. M. Anscombe, P. M. S. Hacker, & J. Schulte, Trans.; P. M. S. Hacker & J. Schulte, Eds.; 4th ed.). Wiley-Blackwell. (Original work published 1953)